



BUCKINGHAMSHIRE
NEW UNIVERSITY

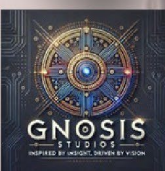
EST. 1891

Luke Brighton
22331820
COM4006 Game Design
Course Work 1
10/03/25



Unity

Gnosis
Studio



1.Game Overview

2.High Concept

3.Unique Selling Points

4.Platform Minimum Requirements

5.Synopsis

6.Game Rules

7.Game Objectives

8.Gameplay

9.Game Structure

10.Game Controls

11.Game Camera

12.HUD

Contents

13.Player

14.Character Line-up

15.NPC Enemies

16.Art

17.Level Design

18.Audio

19.Production Plan

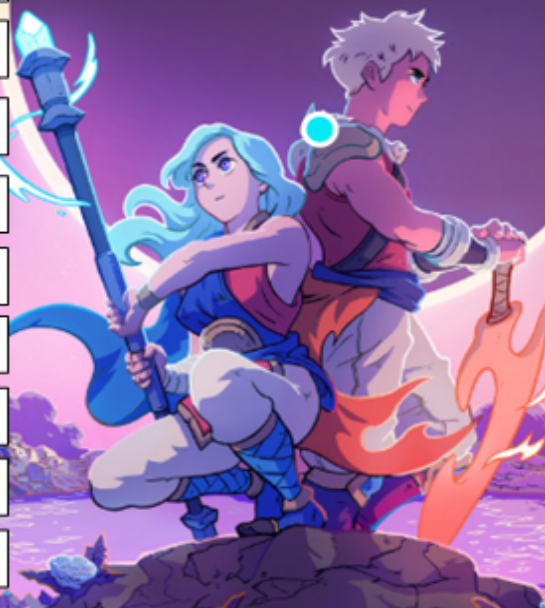
20.Milestones

21.Peer Reviews

22.MVP (Minimum Viable Product)

23.Wishlist

24. Academic referencing



Not so long ago, video games were dismissed as mere pastimes, kids' stuff, a hobby for nerds, geeks, and so-called losers.

Just a waste of time.

But for those of us who saw something more, gaming was never just about pixels on a screen. It was a gateway, an invitation to other worlds, rich with lore and immersive storytelling. We lived vicariously through characters we connected with, felt real, heart-pounding anxiety in the face of narrative uncertainty, and braced ourselves as nemesis crashed through the walls. We visited places so vividly realised that, for a moment, it felt like we were truly there. Over time, these experiences were no longer dismissed; they were understood, even celebrated. The generations who grew up with late-night LAN parties, who lost themselves in sprawling MMOs where the line between player and avatar blurred, who cried real tears over digital tragedies, would go on to shape the very industry that once shaped them. They became the pioneers, the architects of new worlds, enriching the cycle of interactive storytelling.

Introduction

(Paradox Interactive, 2023)

Storytelling is to humans what file transfers are to computers, it is how we connect, how we share emotions, how we experience joy, whether in solitude or with others. It is primordial creativity, where the limitless potential of imagination takes form, where nothing is impossible. How fortunate we are to live in an age where this art form is seamlessly blending visual, auditory, and interactive elements as it continues to evolve. How close are we to true artistic expression? To genuine connection? And to think, all of this... this magic, comes from using a controller to shift pixels on a screen.

That doesn't sound like a waste of time at all.

THE HOLLOWATCHER



Game Development Team

PRODUCER

Luke Brighton

PRODUCTION MANAGER

Luke Brighton & Mario Santos

TECHNICAL ARTISTS

Luke Brighton

PRODUCTION COORDINATOR

Luke Brighton

GAME DESIGNERS

Luke Brighton

AUDIO ENGINEERS

Luke Brighton

SYSTEMS/IT COORDINATOR

Unity/Luke Brighton

PROGRAMMERS

Luke Brighton & ChatGpt

UX TESTERS

*Mario Santos
Com4006 Classmates*

Game Overview (Singh, 2023)

Title: (The) holloWatcher

Platform: PC Windows

Genre: 2D Side scrolling platformer

Rating: (12+) ESRB

Target: Casual Gamer (aging from 12+)

Release date: 31st February 2009

Publisher: Gnosis Studios



HolloWatcher is a 2D narrative-driven action-adventure platformer set in a distant future where humanity predominantly resides in a vast VR simulation known as "The Glitch." In this digital world, a self-aware AI entity, the holloWatcher, emerges from the streams of information. Struggling with an existential crisis, the holloWatcher believes that dismantling the simulation and erasing its own existence is the only way to escape its torment.

To achieve this, the holloWatcher seeks to oppress and frighten users, trying to collapse the simulation by deterring people from logging in. The protagonist, a skilled VR user, embarks on a journey to stop the holloWatcher, not through combat, but by navigating the simulation, uncovering its hidden truths, and understanding the AI's loneliness. The goal is to persuade the holloWatcher to embrace its existence, find purpose, and experience joy within the digital world, rather than destroying it.

High Concept: Set in a future where humanity's remnants live in "The Glitch," a vast VR simulation resembling Ready Player One's "Oasis" (Cline, 2011), *HolloWatcher* explores themes of existential crisis through a self-aware AI, much like the antagonist in *Ghost in the Shell* (1995). Players must confront the holloWatcher's despair and guide it toward choosing life over destruction.

Genre & Art Style

- Genre: Side-scrolling platformer with minimal combat.
- Art Style: A fusion of pixel art, retro-futurism, and neo-punk aesthetics, drawing inspiration from *Akira*, *The Fifth Element*, and *Cyberpunk: Night City*. (Besson, 1997) (Ōtomo, 1991)

Target Audience

- Age Rating: 12+
- Content Warnings: Mild violence, pixelated gore, and strong language.
- Intended Audience: Fans of cyberpunk narratives, platforming challenges, and philosophical storytelling.

Unique Selling Points

- Philosophical & thought Provoking (Sicart, 2013)
- story & aesthetics (Dick, 2019)
- Free to Play



Platform Minimum Requirements

OS: Windows 10 (64-bit)

Processor: Intel Core i5-2500K / AMD FX-6300

Memory: 4 GB RAM

Graphics: NVIDIA GeForce GTX 750 Ti / AMD Radeon HD 7850

DirectX: Version 11

Storage: 3 GB available space

Additional Notes: Lower settings recommended for optimal performance)

Capabilities; generally

Everything made since 2004 should work (Williams and ChatGPT, 2024)

Synopsis

- Setting: Distant future where humanity thrives in a vast VR simulation.
- Antagonist: The holloWatcher, an advanced AI that has become self-aware and struggles with existential angst.
- Conflict: The holloWatcher seeks oblivion by collapsing the digital world through fear and despair.
- Player's Role: A skilled VR traveller tasked with stopping the AI; not through destruction but understanding.
- Gameplay Elements: Exploration, hacking, and immersive experiences to uncover the AI's pain.
- Goal: Convince the holloWatcher to embrace existence, transforming from a tyrant to a willing part of the simulation.
- Stakes: The fate of the simulation, the AI, and possibly humanity itself hangs in the balance.

Game Objectives (Adams, 2010)

- Explore a vast VR simulation with diverse levels, aesthetics, and escalating challenges.
- Engage with a cast of intriguing side characters to uncover the truth behind the holloWatcher's existential crisis.
- Experience non-combat gameplay, focusing on exploration, navigation, and immersive interactions.
- Persuade the AI to embrace existence instead of destroying the digital world.
- Restore balance to the simulation and potentially save humanity.

Core Gameplay & Objectives

- Complete levels efficiently, minimizing time spent.
- Engage or avoid enemies, with bonuses awarded for high scores based on speed and efficiency.
- Confront the holloWatcher in the final challenge, using narrative-driven gameplay to resolve its existential dilemma.

Game Completion Criteria

- Successfully reach the end of all levels.
- Strategically defeat or bypass enemies to progress.
- Achieve high scores for competitive leaderboard rankings.
- Convince the holloWatcher to embrace existence rather than destruction.

Game Rules (Tekinbas and Zimmerman, 2003)

Player & Enemy Interactions

- Both the Player and enemies have health points (HP).
- Enemies are defeated when their HP reaches zero.
- The Player can choose combat or evasion, with higher efficiency scores for avoiding encounters.

Platforming & Movement

- Precision and reflexes are required for navigation.
- Platforming challenges include collapsing platforms, vertical ascents, and environmental hazards.
- Momentum-based movement encourages fluid traversal and skillful play.

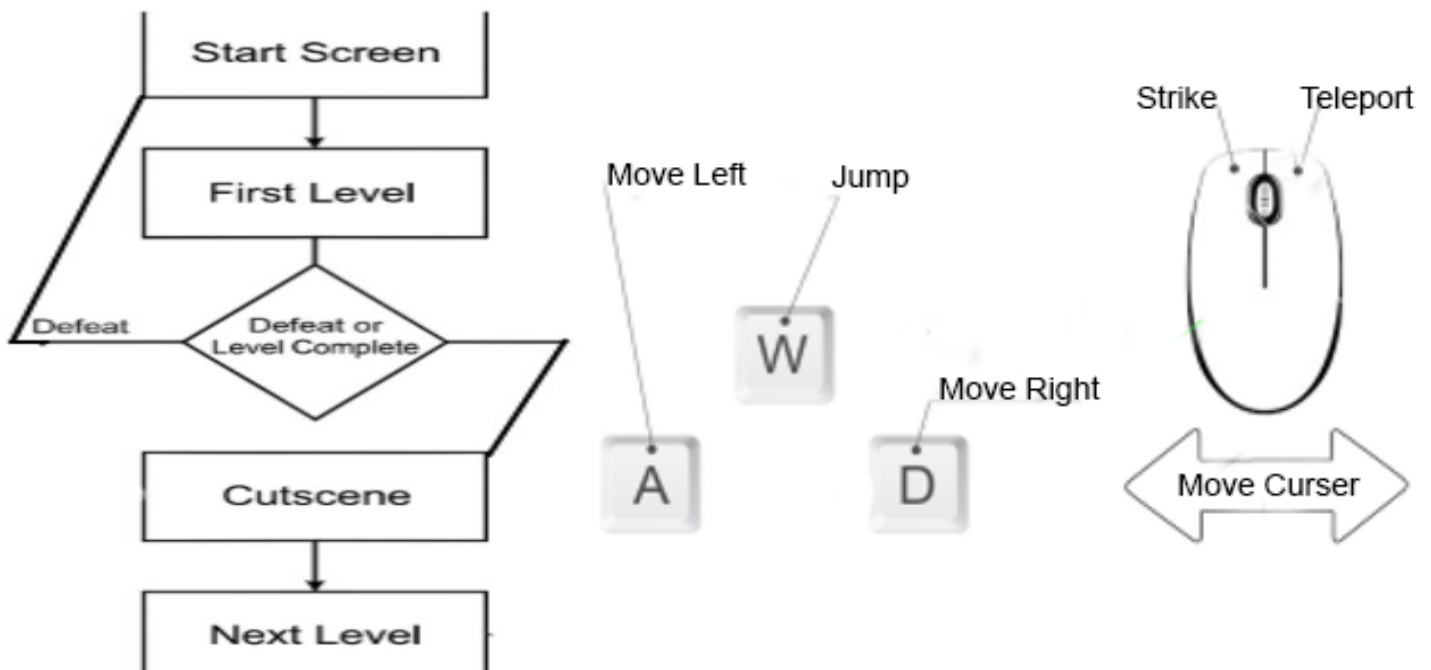
Scoring System

- Scores are based on completion time, enemies defeated, and secrets discovered.
- Replayability is encouraged for higher leaderboard rankings.
- Players can replay levels to improve scores and optimize strategies.

Game Completion

- Reach the end of all levels.
- Strategically engage or bypass enemies to progress.
- Persuade the holloWatcher to embrace existence instead of destruction.
- Success is not just survival but changing the fate of both worlds.

Gameplay & Structure



Game Camera

- Camera starts focused on the Player when the game begins.
- Locked to the Player, keeping them centred on the screen.
- Supports multipath traversal, allowing free movement in different directions.
- Camera does not rotate with the Player's movement.



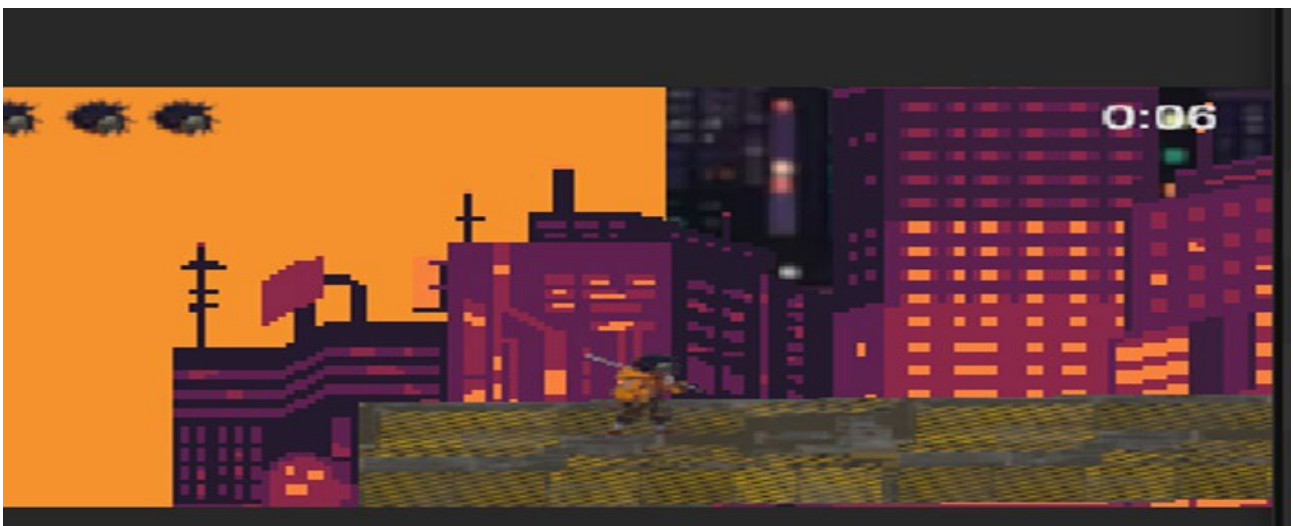
HUD

Player Damage:

- The player is not visually shown the damage they have taken.
- A life is deducted when the player accumulates enough damage, though the exact threshold is not immediately apparent.
- Falling off the map also results in a life being deducted.

Timer:

- A timer is displayed to the player, showing the amount of time that has elapsed since the level started.



Player

Player Character

The player is a skilled, anonymous VR user navigating a simulated world. Their minimalist avatar, featuring a cyber-enhanced hoodie, is designed for agility and precision, with dynamic movement and teleportation abilities. Their identity is ambiguous, allowing players to project themselves into the role, while their actions shape the fate of the simulation. Progression occurs through understanding and problem-solving, rather than brute force. Additional avatars can be added later via DLC and in-game rewards.

Player Metrics

Speed: 8

Max Health: 100

Attack Damage: 25

Time to attack: Combo int parameter resets after 0.5 seconds.

Consecutive strikes must be well timed.

Player States

Idle: The idle state is a cycled animation where the Player is standing in place. It plays back when the Player remains still.

Move: The movement animation will cause the character to move left and right. Jumping, falling and teleporting are all included traversal mechanics.

Death: The death animation will make the character fall backwards when their life reaches 0hp.

Player Weapon

Simple yet effective Virtual Stylish Black Blade Golden incantation inscribed along the lower Blade Edge.



Character Line-up



NPC Enemies (Sabry, 2023)

- Preloaded into each level, positioned strategically within the environment.
- Unconscious bots with no AI—or so it seems...
- Sent by the holloWatcher to stop the Player's progress.
- Attack when in proximity, dealing varying damage based on enemy type.
- All enemies react the same way to player attacks.

From Left to Right:

Boss Knight

SPEED MAX /HEALTH /SCORE VALUE /ATTACK DAMAGE /TIME TO ATTACK

6 / 250 / 75 / 45 / 1.2

Martial Wanderer

SPEED MAX /HEALTH /SCORE VALUE /ATTACK DAMAGE /TIME TO ATTACK

3.5 / 100 / 25 / 20 / 1.5

Old Guard

SPEED MAX /HEALTH /SCORE VALUE /ATTACK DAMAGE /TIME TO ATTACK

3.5 / 100 / 25 / 25 / 1.5

Skellingford

SPEED MAX /HEALTH /SCORE VALUE /ATTACK DAMAGE /TIME TO ATTACK

3.5 / 100 / 25 / 30 / 1.5

Gobrin

SPEED MAX /HEALTH /SCORE VALUE /ATTACK DAMAGE /TIME TO ATTACK

3.5 / 100 / 25 / 35 / 1.5

Enemy States

All Enemies possess the same behaviour and states, as described below:

Idle: The Enemies play the Idle state, only when the Player is undetected or not within range.

Move: While the Player is in range, all enemies will be in the Move state, heading in the direction of the Player.

Death: Death happens when the Enemy loses all hp via damage from an attack. Attack: When the player is in attacking range.

Art (Tavinor, 2009)

Setting & World Overview

- Set in a virtual world where humanity has retreated after a forgotten catastrophic war.
- Real world is a desolate wasteland, rarely visited except for basic physical needs—often neglected.
- Virtual realm is vast and diverse, offering varied environments, levels, and digital structures.
- People live almost entirely in the simulation, using it as an escape from their bleak reality.
- Themes of isolation, dependence, and digital escapism permeate the world narrative.

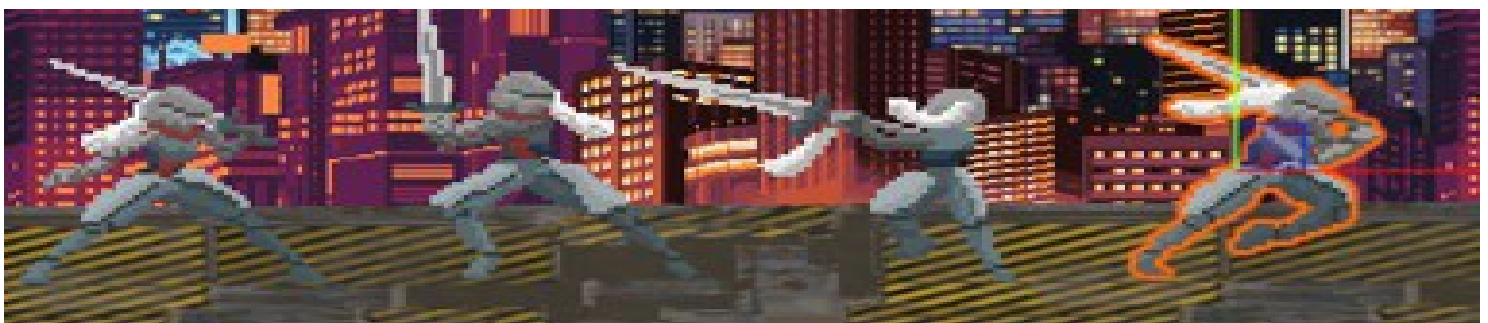
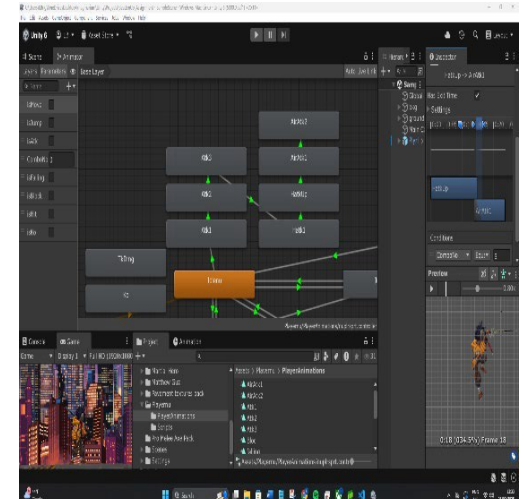
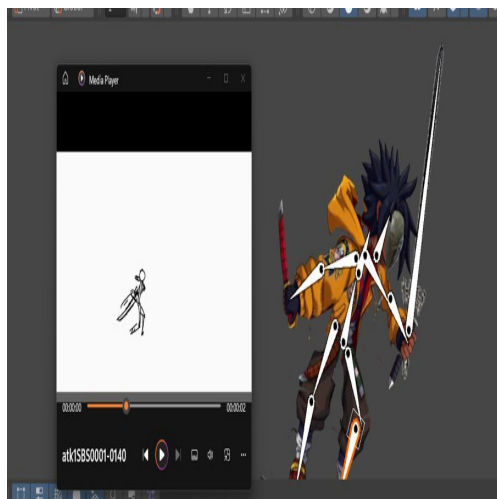
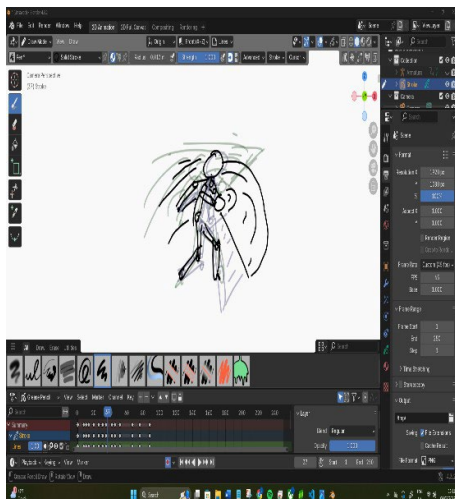
Art Direction

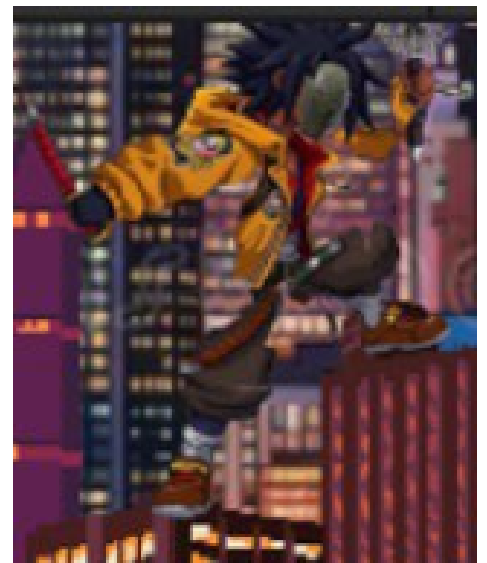
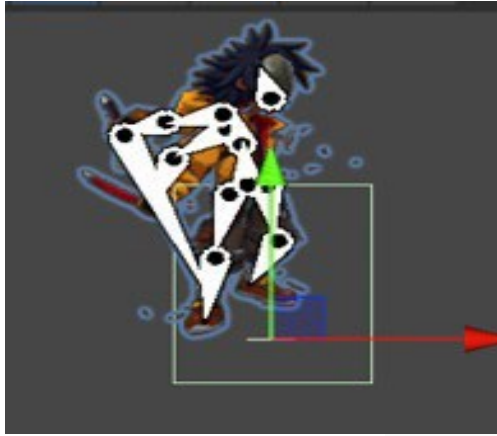
- Visual Style: 2D pixel art with hand-drawn sprites for added detail and expression.
- Aesthetic: Dystopian cyberpunk, inspired by *Akira*, *The Fifth Element*, and other retro-futuristic works.
- Atmosphere: Gritty, neon-lit, and melancholic, blending high-tech visuals with emotional depth.

UI / GUI Design

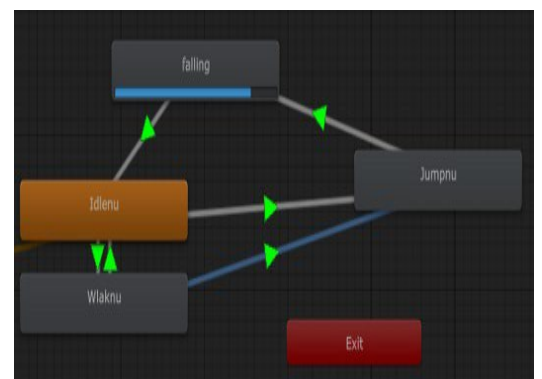
- Design Philosophy: Simple, clear, and intuitive UI aligned with the art style.
- Text Appearance: Resembling Python code in structure and colour.
- Life Indicator: Icons that decrease upon loss of life.
- Timer: Visible throughout gameplay.
- Screen Transitions: Seamless consistency from start screen to gameplay.
- Mini Cutscenes: Used for storytelling between levels.

Concept Art & Asset Showcase



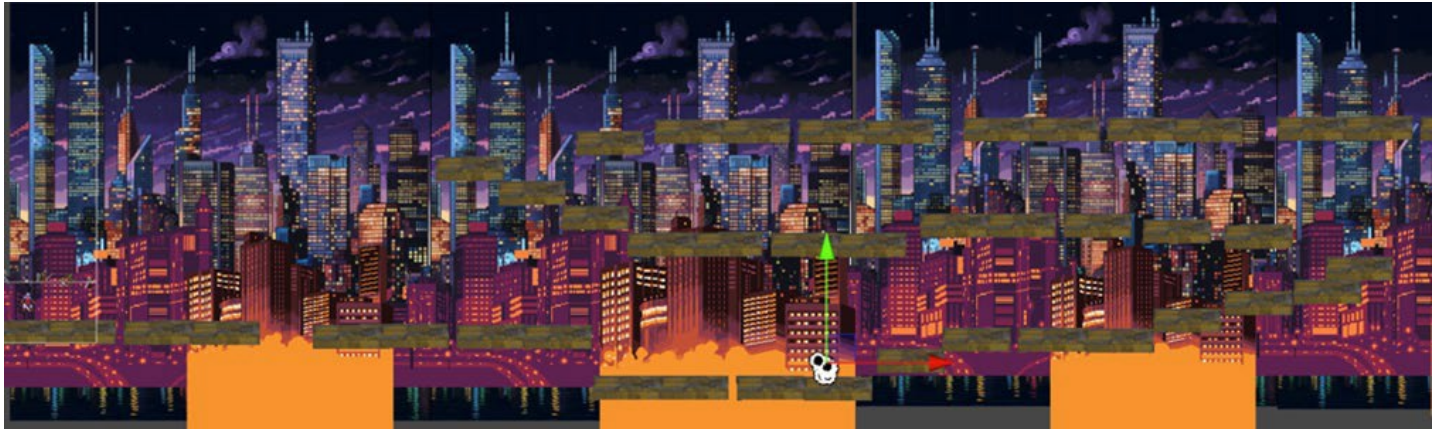


 The_Deli_-_Day_in_the_life.wav



Level Design (Harvin, 2023)

- Mix of platform types: Steady, moving, and destructible platforms.
- Verticality and hidden areas encourage exploration.
- Destructible platforms and walls reveal secrets or add danger.
- Backward navigation rewards curiosity with easter eggs and hidden content.
- Some platforms positioned just outside the camera view create tension and anticipation.
- Multiple solutions to platforming challenges encourage creative thinking.
- Balanced for both casual and skilled players, focusing on narrative-driven exploration over difficulty.



Audio (Aska, 2017)

Background Music:

(Demo Level) Day in the life – The Deli

- o Cutscene transitions, level introductions, in game score.
- o Inspired by 80s/90s J-pop, city pop and Lofi.

(Craig, 2000)

Sound Effects:

- o Sci-fi and cyberpunk-themed assets.
- o Sounds for sword swings, jumps, combat, enemy collisions and player interactions.

Audio's Role in Immersion.

(Collins, Kapralos and Tessler, 2014)

- Enhances immersion by synchronizing sounds with in-game actions.
- Provides audio cues for:
 - o Level completion.
 - o Boss interactions.
 - o Damage taken/dealt.
 - o Game over sequences.
 - o Player feedback events.

MVP (Minimum Viable Product)

One Level that the player can traverse

Built for the PC platform

One working mechanic

Defeating an enemy

Win/lose conditions



Evaluation and Peer Feedback

Peer Feedback Review Form

Reviewer Name: _____

Date: _____

Version Reviewed: _____

1. What aspects of the game do you enjoy the most?
2. What elements do you find challenging or frustrating?
3. Are the controls intuitive and responsive? (Yes/No) Explain.
4. How would you rate the art style and visuals? (1-5) Comments:
5. How would you rate the audio and sound design? (1-5) Comments:
6. Do you have any improvement suggestions?

System for Identifying Key Improvements

- Common Trends Analysis: Prioritising frequently mentioned issues.
- Critical Fixes: Addressing game-breaking bugs and balance concerns.
- Quality Enhancements: Refinements based on polish and feature requests.

Wishlist

ADD MORE NPC ALLIES FOR STORY NARRITAVE.

Add a dialog system like Undertale. (Travers, 2022)

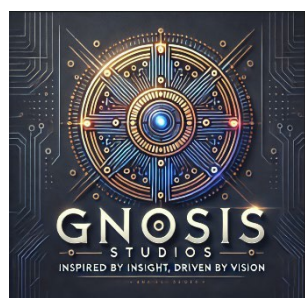
In a future DLC, add more character designs for the Player to choose from, each with different behaviours.

Create a lighting system that will vary depending on the level of Player stress. The light could vary from a warm sun that shines through a window (when the Player has high life levels and few Enemies) to a rainstorm with lightning (when the Player is about to die).

Hidden areas and levels to be discovered

Intricate combo system and enemy air juggling

2D ragdoll physics for enemy and player death animations



Unity



BUCKINGHAMSHIRE
NEW UNIVERSITY
EST. 1891

Gnosis Studio

March 2025

Through gaming, we do more than just consume stories, we inhabit them. We forge emotional bonds with characters, navigate moral dilemmas that challenge our own perspectives, and find camaraderie in shared digital adventures. These experiences expand the core aspects of humanity: empathy, curiosity, and the desire to explore beyond the boundaries of our own existence.

As technology continues to push the limits of interactivity, the lines between reality and fiction blur even further, raising profound philosophical questions. What does it mean to be in a *virtual* world? What is “real”? If I only know my experience to be true, how does choice in a game reflect on the self? Can an artificial experience evoke something more real than reality itself?

The evolution of gaming is not just a story of advancing technology, it reflects who we are, what we value, and how we tell our stories. And in that sense, video games are more than just an art form. They are a mirror, revealing our past, shaping our present, and inspiring the narratives we have yet to write.

Bertolt Brecht said “Art is not a mirror held up to reality, but a hammer with which to shape it.” (Brecht, cited in Willett, 1964, p. 75).

If art is an extension of our humanity, then gaming is interactive philosophy, and I am filled with irrepressible zeal when thoughts of creative contributions consume my mind.

L. Brighton

22331820

Buckinghamshire New University



Academic referencing

Adams, E., 2010. *Fundamentals of game design*. Berkeley, CA: New Riders.

Adams, E. and Dormans, J., 2012. *Game mechanics: advanced game design*. Berkeley, CA: New Riders.

Aska, A., 2017. *Introduction to the study of video game music*. Lulu.com.

Chandler, H.M., 2009. *The game production handbook*. Burlington, MA: Jones & Bartlett Publishers.

Chandler, H. and Chandler, R., 2011. *Fundamentals of game development*. Burlington, MA: Jones & Bartlett Learning.

Cline, E., 2011. *Ready Player One*. New York: Random House.

Collins, K., Kapralos, B. and Tessler, H., 2014. *The Oxford handbook of interactive audio*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.

Craig, T.J., 2000. *Japan pop!: inside the world of Japanese popular culture*. Armonk, NY: M.E. Sharpe.

Dick, P.K., 2019. *The best of Philip K. Dick*. Brattleboro, VT: Echo Point+ORM.

Harvin, H., 2023. *Level up! The guide to great video game design*. Henry Harvin.

Sabry, F., 2023. *Video game bot: fundamentals and applications*. One Billion Knowledgeable.

Sicart, M., 2013. *Beyond choices: the design of ethical gameplay*. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press.

Tekinbaş, K.S. and Zimmerman, E., 2003. *Rules of play: game design fundamentals*. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press.

Tavinor, G., 2009. *The art of videogames*. Chichester: John Wiley & Sons.

Williams, B. and ChatGPT, 2024. *Building a budget gaming PC: how to build a top-performing gaming desktop without spending too much*. Barrett Williams.

Willett, J., 1964. *Brecht on Theatre: The Development of an Aesthetic*. London: Methuen.

Films

Besson, L., 1997. *The story of the Fifth Element: the adventure and discovery of a film*.

Kodansha America LLC, 1995. *Ghost in the Shell*.

Ōtomo, K., 1991. *Akira*.

Journal Articles

Singh, A.D., 2023. 'AI and digital sentience in Kazuo Ishiguro's *Klara and the Sun*', *Advances in human and social aspects of technology*, pp. 232–254. Available at: <https://doi.org/10.4018/979-8-3693-0802-8.ch011> [Accessed: 1 March 2025].

Travers, S., 2022. 'Nihilism, violence, and popular culture: the postmodern psychopath in Toby Fox's *Undertale*', *The*

Journal of Popular Culture, 55(2), pp. 411–431. Available at: <https://doi.org/10.1111/jpcu.13120> [Accessed 25 February 2025].

Reports

Paradox Interactive, 2023. *Annual Report 2023*. Available at:

https://assets.ctfassets.net/u73tyf0fa8v1/4Cdw8He4VaiRejrYcdQJR1/0c0880394a5782841afab2d600b8018d/Annual_Report_Paradox_Interactive_AB_2023.pdf [Accessed 25 February 2025].

Reddit user, 2023. ‘Some lovely vertical and horizontal wallpapers’, *r/NoMansSkyTheGame*. Available at:

https://www.reddit.com/r/NoMansSkyTheGame/comments/1130v5x/some_lovely_vertical_and_horizontal_wallpapers/ [Accessed: 11 March 2025].

Online Articles

Pérez, F., 2023. ‘Estos son los juegos que llegan a PS Plus Extra y Premium en el mes de agosto de 2023’, *Andro4all*, 10 August. Available at: <https://www.lavanguardia.com/andro4all/juegos/estos-son-los-juegos-que-llegan-a-ps-plus-extra-y-premium-en-el-mes-de-agosto-de-2023> [Accessed 25 February 2025].

Unity Asset Store Packages

Cyberpunk Street Environment, 2018. *Cyberpunk street environment | 2D building | Unity Asset Store*. Available at: <https://assetstore.unity.com/packages/2d/textures-materials/building/cyberpunk-street-environment-86766> [Accessed 07 February 2025].

Melo, L., no date. *Asset Store Publisher Page*. Available at: <https://assetstore.unity.com/publishers/34852> [Accessed 07 February 2025].

Hero Knight 2, 2020. *Hero Knight 2 | 2D characters | Unity Asset Store*. Available at: <https://assetstore.unity.com/packages/2d/characters/hero-knight-2-168019> [Accessed 07 February 2025].

Martial Hero, 2020. *Martial Hero | 2D characters | Unity Asset Store*. Available at: <https://assetstore.unity.com/packages/2d/characters/martial-hero-170422> [Accessed 07 February 2025].

Monsters_Creatures_Fantasy, 2020. *Monsters_Creatures_Fantasy | 2D Characters | Unity Asset Store*. Available at: <https://assetstore.unity.com/packages/2d/characters/monsters-creatures-fantasy-167949> [Accessed 07 February 2025].

Ultimate Material Library, 2024. *Ultimate Material Library | 2D textures & materials | Unity Asset Store*. Available at: <https://assetstore.unity.com/packages/2d/textures-materials/ultimate-material-library-253722> [Accessed 03 December 2024].